

Until January this year, Jyothi Yarraji had never competed in the 60-metre indoors hurdles event. When she stepped out on the track at the Aarhus Sprint'n'Jump in Denmark, she was excited to simply soak it all in. "It's a lot more aggressive and intense—nothing like running outdoors. Every single move counts, a small mistake and it's over," says Yarraji, 23. The inexperience hardly mattered. In the very first race, she smashed Gayathri Govindaraj's national record (8.34 seconds) from 2016 after clocking 8.20 seconds. Since then, she has progressively bettered her own mark on four other occasions.

On February 12, she ran her last race at the Asian Indoor Athletics Championships in Nur-Sultan in Kazakhstan. Her timing of 8.13 seconds wasn't just her fastest time yet—it also won her a silver behind Japan's Masumi Aoki (8.01 seconds). "I managed to get another personal best during the heats, so I thought to myself why not go even faster. The focus was on running intelligently, the medal was never on my mind," she says. "It was the first time I held the Indian flag on the podium. It has been my dream."

Jyothi Yarraji broke **the national record for 100-metre** hurdles on four occasions in 2022

Chasing records is becoming a routine of sorts for Yarraji ever since she took to athletics during her school days in Visakhapatnam. Things were difficult back home. Her father is employed as a security guard and her mother works part-time as a cleaner at a hospital. But she continued to focus on the track life, and the effort paid off when she burst onto the scene last year. Yarraji broke the national record for 100-metre hurdles on four occasions in 2022. She ended the year on a high, clocking 12.82 seconds at the National Open Athletics Championship in Bengaluru, the first Indian woman to go under 13 seconds.

This year, she wants to focus on an Olympic qualification for 2024, as well as the World Championships and the Asian Games. India's only medal at any of these events in Yarraji's discipline was won by Manjit Walia at the Bangkok Asian Games in 1966 (at the time, it was 80m instead of today's 100m).

In December last year, the Athletics Federation of India announced 13.63 seconds as the qualification mark for the Asian Games in Hangzhou. Going by her performance last season and her current form, Yarraji looks good to make the cut.

Over the past year, she has worked on her speed and strength with coach James Hillier at the Reliance Foundation Odisha High Performance Centre. She credits him for the positivity he has brought to her life. "Sketching has also helped me a lot. It allows me to express myself and helps release a lot of emotions." And, perhaps, break records at will. ■

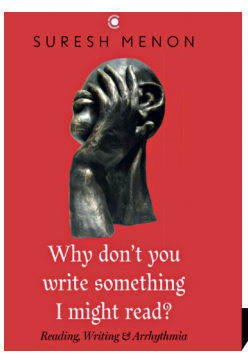
Shail Desai

BOOKS

MAN OF MANY WORLDS

In his new book, **Suresh Menon** takes a break from sports writing to pursue his other interests: literature, art, philosophy

his house many years earlier; Ved Mehta detests the appellation "blind writer"; among sportsmen whose byline appeared in newspaper columns, only Bishen Singh Bedi and Sunil Gavaskar did not use ghostwriters. H.G. Wells, Arthur Conan Doyle, Mark Twain, Perry Mason and others march through the book, but Menon offers little insight of his own and instead quotes other writers. The result is a collection of dry, Wikipedia-style essays.



WHY DON'T YOU WRITE SOMETHING I MIGHT READ? Reading, Writing and Arrhythmia
by Suresh Menon
CONTEXT
₹499; 275 pages

The interesting parts, naturally, are when Menon talks about sports and Bengaluru's bookshops. He describes Eduardo Galeano writing about Pele ("When he executed a free kick, his opponents in the wall wanted to turn around to face the net so as not to miss the goal"). As editor of *Wisden*, he remembers haranguing Pico Iyer into writing 1,500 words about cricket. Talking about the hours he spent at his favourite Premier Bookstore in Bengaluru, Menon recalls that he always took the same route inside, starting with new arrivals, then moving to science and art sections and ending up in the sports section just past the eccentric owner T.S. Shanbhag.

Great sportswriting, he says, transcends balls and bats to display the qualities of literature: incision, wit, force and vision, suffused with style and substance. Muhammad Ali inspired some of the best writing on boxing. Did early sportswriters think of themselves as literary figures? The first cricket writer was a woman, Mary Russel Mitford, who wrote extensively on rural life. "I doubt whether there will be any scene in the world more delightful than a cricket match," she wrote. Ernest Hemingway, Norman Mailer, Daniel Defoe, George Plimpton, all wrote great sports stories. Literary people writing about a populist activity, Menon says, could not resist the temptation to force life lessons into their sportswriting. Sometimes it worked, sometimes it didn't. ■

G. Krishnan